

Photographs: **AFP**

SAI SUDHARSAN, *23*

Gujarat Titans

MATCHES: 15 RUNS: 759
AVG: 54.2 STRIKE RATE: 156.2

A saintly name, a composed style and an executioner's mindset—Sai Sudharsan emerged as the nemesis of bowlers and the envy of rival franchises this IPL. The elegant left-hander was the backbone of GT's 2025 campaign, finishing as the tournament's highest run-scorer with 759 runs at a strike rate of 156.2 in 15 matches. No surprise then that he picked up the Orange Cap (for most runs scored), was named Emerging Player of the Year, struck the most fours (88) in the tournament, and walked away with the fan-driven 'Fantasy King of the Season' prize. His crowning moment came on May 18, when he dismantled Delhi Capitals with a sublime 108 n.o. off 61 balls, anchoring a 205-run opening stand with captain Shubman Gill. It wasn't just a century—it was a lesson in timing, temperament and tact, executed with minimal fuss and for maximum impact. In between IPL matches, Sudharsan received another nod of validation: his maiden Test call-up for India's series against England.

—Amitabh Srivastava

DIGVESH RATHI, *25*

Lucknow Super Giants

MATCHES: 13 WICKETS: 14
ECONOMY: 8.2
STRIKE RATE: 22.3

Controversy's favourite child, enfant terrible of IPL 2025, ultimate entertainer—there are several ways to describe the leg spinner, one of the breakout stars of the Delhi Premier League 2024. Most will agree that Digvesh Rathi made a compelling case for why IPL is prime-time entertainment in the truest sense. He wasn't there to win the fair play award but to unsettle the opposition and win matches (cue the imaginary notebook celebration), even if it involves a failed 'Mankading'. To Rathi goes the (dis)honour of earning enough demerit points to get a one-match suspension. But amidst all the drama, Digvesh also took 14 wickets in 13 matches (best haul for the LSG) and flummoxed batters with a run-up that would perhaps have the legendary leggie Abdul Qadir cheering from the heavens. Simply put, Rathi was every IPL fan's best bad boy this year. ***—SS***

